

Colour Field

The term 'Colour Field' was originally used c.1950 to describe the work of painters such as Mark Rothko (1903–70), Barnett Newman (1905–70), Robert Motherwell (1915–91), Ad Reinhardt (1913–67) and Clyfford Still (1904–80). They covered large canvases with single or limited colour areas whose edges dissolve or merge together. There are no links to the outside world, no recognizable elements and no obvious emotional input by the artists themselves. Yet they were produced to elicit emotional or contemplative reactions in viewers. The lack of frames also blurs distinctions with the wider world, and most exude a tranquillity intended to inspire contemplation.

'Post-Painterly Abstraction' is a broad term used to encompass a variety of styles developed in reaction to the painterly, gestural approach of some Abstract Expressionists. Writer Clement Greenberg (1909–94) first coined the phrase to describe various developments of Abstract Expressionism, including particularly Colour Field and Hard Edge painting.



Rothko, *Untitled*, 1966–7